

Jusuf Nurkić: The Bosnian Beast Has Bounced Back (2025–26)

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Baseline Level

Jusuf Nurkić's season in Utah has marked a clear bounceback, reestablishing him as a reliable, functional NBA center after a few uneven years. He's no longer asked to carry offense or anchor a defense, but his rebounding, passing, and feel for the game have returned as consistent strengths.

Table 1: Season baseline through 2026-01-24

Season	Team	GP	MPG	PTS	TRB	AST	TOV	FG%	3PA	3P%	FT%
2025-26	UTA	36	26.5	11.2	10.2	5	2.4	0.508	1.7	0.355	0.551

Rebounding Value

Top 5 rebounding games

Table 2: Top 5 rebounding games (season to date)

Date	Opp	MP	ORB	DRB	TRB	AST	PTS
2026-01-20	UTA vs. MIN	31	3	15	18	10	16
2025-11-05	UTA @ DET	33	3	14	17	4	6
2025-12-12	UTA @ MEM	28	5	12	17	7	13
2026-01-12	UTA @ CLE	30	3	14	17	3	11
2026-01-07	UTA @ OKC	33	5	10	15	4	15

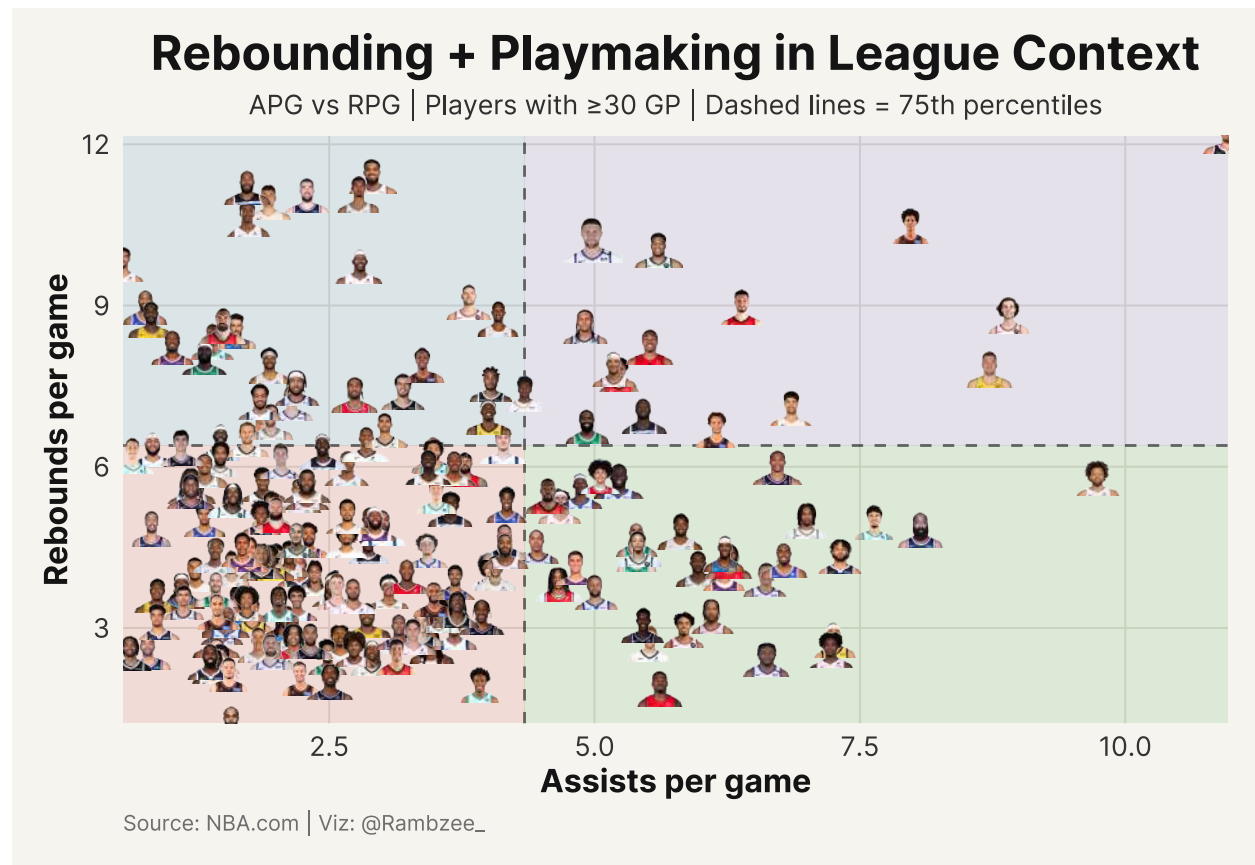
Rebound Rate (OREB% / DREB% / REB%)

Table 3: Rebounding Rate Profile

OREB%	DREB%	REB%
0.09	0.273	0.18

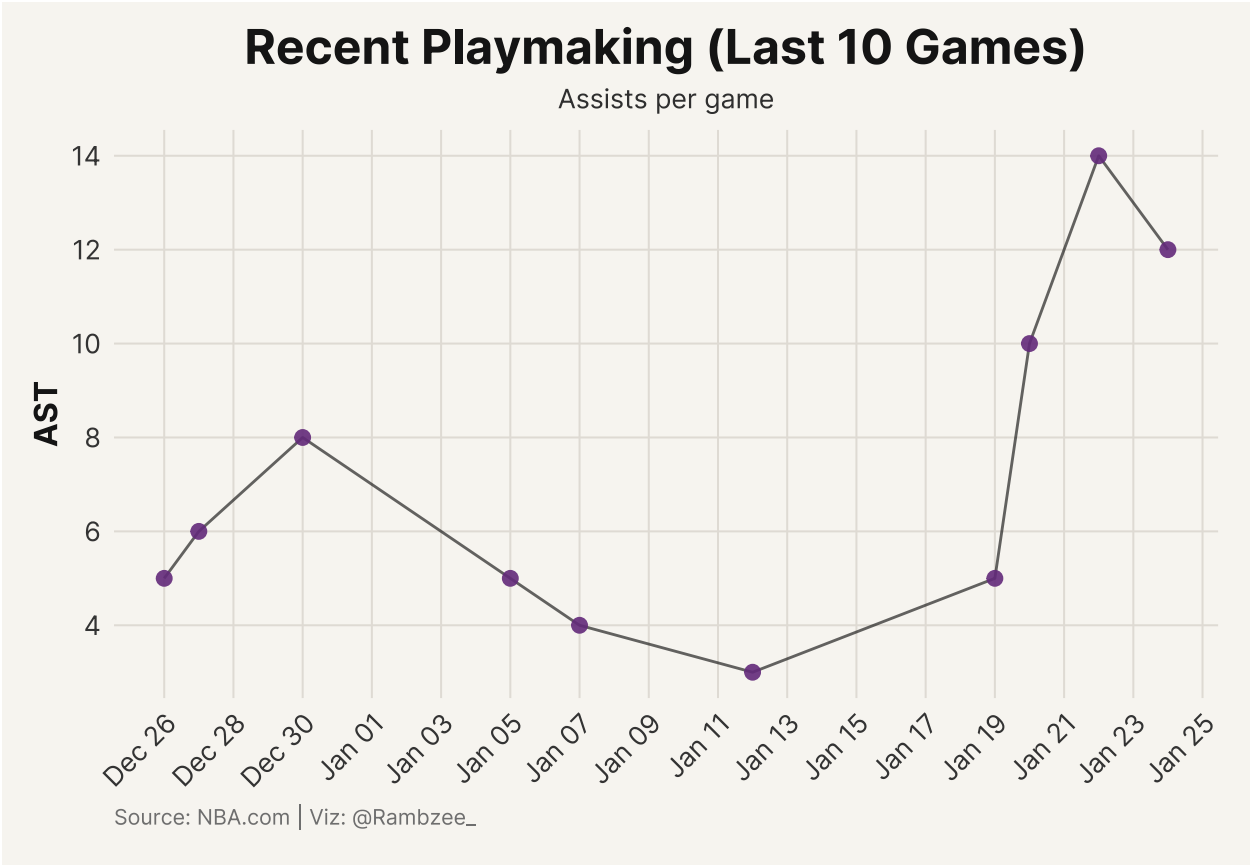
Rebounding is Nurkić's most dependable contribution. Among players with 30+ games played, he ranks second in defensive rebounding rate and eighth league-wide in overall rebounding percentage. He consistently ends possessions through veteran positioning and strength, carving out space and moving bodies to secure the ball. At his best, he controls the defensive glass outright, stringing together multiple fantastic performances on the boards this season.

REB/AST unique value



Nurkić occupies a relatively rare space as a high-level rebounder and passer. He can occasionally be too willing to test tight windows, but he consistently spots cutters and makes quick reads out of the short roll. That combination places him in similar playmaking territory to bigger offensive hubs like Giannis, Paolo, and Şengün, even if his usage and scoring burden are far more modest.

Recent playmaking (last 10 games)



Nurkić’s playmaking value has shown up consistently over the course of the season, with several high-assist performances mixed throughout. That ability has peaked most recently, as he recorded three straight triple-doubles while averaging 12 assists per game over that stretch. Zooming out slightly, he is averaging 7.2 assists per game over his last ten, showcasing that the passing is not a short-term spike, but a steady part of how Nurkić impacts offense.

Table 4: Screen Assists per Game (Centers)

Player	Team	Age	GP	Min	Screen Ast
Jusuf Nurkić	UTA	31	36	26.5	4.6
Rudy Gobert	MIN	33	45	31.6	4.2
Luke Kornet	SAS	30	37	24.2	4.1
Domantas Sabonis	SAC	29	16	29.9	3.9

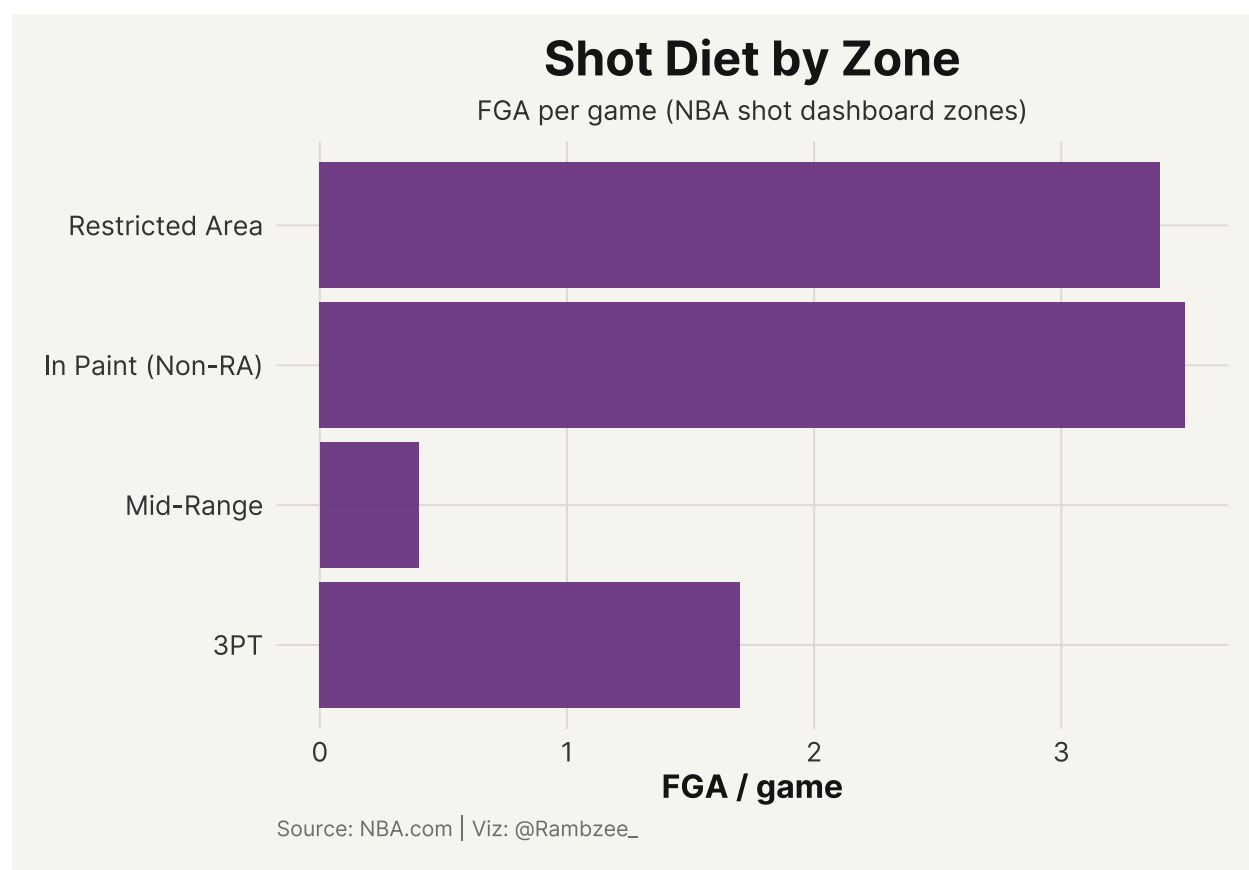
Nurkić’s screen-setting has been a potent source of offense this season. He leads all centers in screen assists per game, consistently freeing ball-handlers and creating scoring chances without touching the ball. It reinforces his value as a connective piece in the offense, adding impact even when his own scoring is limited.

Scoring Profile

Shot dashboard zones (Restricted Area / Non-RA Paint / 3s)

Table 5: Shot profile by NBA.com zones (per game)

Zone	FGM	FGA	FG%
Restricted Area	2.0	3.4	0.59
In Paint (Non-RA)	1.9	3.5	0.54
Mid-Range	0.1	0.4	0.23
3PT	0.6	1.7	0.35



Scoring is the least impactful part of Nurkić's offensive game. He can finish plays at the rim, shows good touch, and will take open threes, but his effectiveness fades when asked to create. His offense is best limited to dump-offs and seals, where he can take advantage of his size.

Defense

Defensively, Nurkić has remained serviceable despite a shaky Jazz defensive ecosystem. Among players defending at least two shots per game at the rim, he ranks 28th in DFG Diff%, holding opponents 5.6 points worse than expected inside six feet, similar territory to Donovan Clingan and Jalen Duren. That metric has clear limitations, but it helps illustrate that Nurkić can still hold his ground within a team defense rather than being a complete zero.

Table 6: Rim defense company (shots < 6 ft) | Centers only | Qualified: DFGA >= 2.5 | Metric: DFG Diff% (pp; lower = better)

Player	Team	DFGA / G	Diff%	Rank
Jalen Duren	DET	4.9	-6.2	26
Donovan Clingan	POR	6.4	-5.9	27
Jusuf Nurkić	UTA	5.0	-5.6	28
Karlo Matković	NOP	2.9	-5.5	29
Jonas Valančiūnas	DEN	2.7	-5.4	30

Table 7: Deflections per Game - Centers (Nurkić tied for 2nd)

Rank	Player	Team	Age	GP	Min	Deflections
1	Alperen Şengün	HOU	23	36	35.1	3.1
2	Jusuf Nurkić	UTA	31	36	26.5	3.0
2	Nikola Jokić	DEN	30	32	34.6	3.0

He compensates for lost mobility with anticipation and activity, tied for second among centers in deflections per game by reading actions early and disrupting passing lanes. While he no longer anchors a defense as he once did in Portland, his IQ and engagement allow him to hold up within a team scheme.

Closing Summary

This season has looked like a real bounce-back for Nurkić, with his strengths showing up more consistently. He still rebounds at a high level, moves the ball well for a center, and helps offenses stay organized without needing touches. His scoring is best when he's finishing plays, and while he's no longer a defensive anchor, he can hold his own in the right setup. For a playoff team or a group needing to steady the center spot, he makes sense as a dependable backup or short-term solution.